



Does Technology Reduce or Amplify Financial Stress? A Cognitive-Behavioral Perspective on Nigerian Postgraduate Students

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ABSTRAK

Stres keuangan di kalangan mahasiswa pascasarjana menjadi isu yang semakin meningkat di era digital, khususnya seiring dengan pesatnya adopsi perangkat keuangan digital yang dapat sekaligus mengurangi maupun memperburuk tekanan psikologis. Penelitian ini bertujuan untuk mengkaji apakah teknologi mampu mereduksi atau justru memperkuat stres keuangan pada mahasiswa pascasarjana di Nigeria melalui perspektif kognitif-perilaku. Penelitian ini menggunakan desain konseptual dan analitis dengan pendekatan kualitatif berbasis teori yang berlandaskan pada Cognitive-Behavioral Theory (CBT). Data dikumpulkan dari sumber sekunder berupa sekitar 70 artikel jurnal bereputasi, dokumen kebijakan, dan studi empiris yang dipublikasikan pada periode 2015–2024, yang diperoleh melalui basis data Scopus, Web of Science, Google Scholar, dan JSTOR. Analisis data dilakukan menggunakan analisis tematik dan komparatif, yang kemudian diinterpretasikan secara teoritis berdasarkan prinsip CBT. Hasil penelitian menunjukkan bahwa teknologi keuangan digital memiliki peran ganda. Di satu sisi, aplikasi penganggaran, perbankan digital, dan platform tabungan daring mampu meningkatkan kesadaran finansial, efikasi diri, serta regulasi emosi mahasiswa. Di sisi lain, penyalahgunaan layanan fintech, pinjaman digital yang impulsif, paparan penipuan daring, dan kelebihan informasi memicu distorsi kognitif yang memperparah kecemasan dan perilaku keuangan maladaptif. Temuan ini menegaskan bahwa stres keuangan lebih banyak dipengaruhi oleh interpretasi kognitif dan strategi koping mahasiswa dibandingkan oleh teknologi itu sendiri. Dengan demikian, dapat disimpulkan bahwa perangkat keuangan digital hanya dapat mereduksi stres keuangan apabila diimbangi dengan keterampilan kognitif-perilaku dan literasi keuangan yang memadai.

ABSTRACT

Financial stress among postgraduate students has become an increasing concern in the digital era, particularly with the rapid adoption of digital financial tools that may both alleviate and intensify psychological distress. This study aims to examine whether technology reduces or amplifies financial stress among Nigerian postgraduate students through a cognitive-behavioral perspective. The study employed a conceptual and analytical research design using a qualitative, theory-driven approach grounded in Cognitive-Behavioral Theory (CBT). Data were collected from secondary sources, including approximately 70 peer-reviewed journal articles, policy documents, and empirical studies published between 2015 and 2024, retrieved from Scopus, Web of Science, Google Scholar, and JSTOR. Data analysis was conducted using thematic and comparative analysis, followed by theory-driven interpretation based on CBT principles. The findings indicate that digital financial technologies play a dual role. On one hand, tools such as budgeting applications, mobile banking, and online savings platforms enhance financial awareness, self-efficacy, and emotional regulation. On the other hand, misuse of fintech services, impulsive digital borrowing, exposure to fraud, and information overload trigger cognitive distortions that exacerbate anxiety and maladaptive financial behaviors. The results highlight that financial stress is shaped more by students' cognitive interpretations and coping strategies than by technology itself. It is concluded that digital financial tools can reduce financial stress only when accompanied by adequate cognitive-behavioral skills and financial literacy.

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1. INTRODUCTION

Rapid development of digital technology has significantly transformed personal financial management practices across the world. Financial transactions that previously relied on traditional banking channels are now increasingly conducted through digital platforms such as mobile banking, digital wallets, online lending systems,

and financial technology (fintech) applications (Adeyemo, 2023). Digital financial services promise efficiency, accessibility, and convenience for users, especially among young adults and university students who are highly engaged with digital environments. Nevertheless, technological convenience may also generate unintended consequences, including impulsive spending patterns, easy access to short-term credit, and exposure to poorly regulated lending platforms that potentially intensify financial stress (Nwadi et al., 2025). Increasing fintech adoption among Nigerian university students has therefore raised questions regarding whether digital financial tools genuinely improve financial well-being or instead create new forms of financial vulnerability (Adediran & Okonkwo, 2023; Ibrahim & Eze, 2023).

Economic conditions in Nigeria further complicate the financial experiences of university students, particularly those pursuing postgraduate education. Rising inflation, unstable employment opportunities, and broader economic uncertainty have contributed to increased financial pressure on students and their families (National Bureau of Statistics, 2023; National Bureau of Statistics, 2024). Postgraduate students frequently face additional financial obligations such as tuition payments, research expenses, and family responsibilities while often lacking stable income sources (Igbinedion & Adeyemi, 2023; Yusuf & Olayiwola, 2022). Limited financial aid and scholarship opportunities intensify these pressures, leading many students to rely on informal financial support, part-time employment, or digital borrowing platforms (Edem et al., 2023; Oladeji & Bamidele, 2022). Financial constraints have also been associated with delayed graduation and reduced academic productivity among postgraduate students in Nigerian universities (Adebayo & Ibrahim, 2023; Ajayi & Okonkwo, 2023).

Financial stress represents a multidimensional challenge affecting both economic stability and psychological well-being. Research in Nigerian higher education contexts indicates that financial difficulties frequently produce anxiety, emotional distress, and reduced academic persistence among postgraduate students (Chukwuemeka & Omotosho, 2021; Ogunyemi & Balogun, 2021; Oluwasegun & Uche, 2022). Students often develop coping strategies such as entrepreneurship, part-time employment, and reliance on family support to manage financial pressure (Akanbi & Aremu, 2022; Edem et al., 2023; Ugwuanyi et al., 2021). Digital financial platforms may provide additional tools for managing financial resources, including budgeting applications and investment platforms that support financial planning (Ojo & Afolabi, 2024; Oyediran & Udo, 2023). However, simplified access to digital credit and online lending systems may also encourage excessive borrowing behaviors and financial dependency, thereby increasing financial stress rather than reducing it (Adediran & Okonkwo, 2023; Adeyemo, 2023).

Existing literature on student financial well-being often emphasizes structural economic factors such as tuition costs, inflation, and limited financial assistance, while psychological processes underlying financial stress receive comparatively less attention. Financial literacy research highlights the importance of financial knowledge and budgeting skills in shaping responsible financial behavior (Lusardi & Mitchell, 2014; Onyishi, et al., 2021). Nevertheless, financial stress is not solely determined by economic constraints but is also influenced by cognitive interpretations, emotional responses, and behavioral decision-making processes. Cognitive-Behavioral Theory (CBT) provides a valuable theoretical framework for understanding how individuals interpret stressful situations and develop behavioral responses to those challenges (Beck, 1976; Dobson & Dozois, 2019; Onyishi, et al., 2021). Empirical studies have demonstrated that cognitive-behavioral interventions can significantly reduce academic stress and improve psychological resilience among students (Eneogu et al., 2024; Eze et al., 2023; Hofmann et al., 2012; Nwadi et al., 2025). Current research addressing fintech adoption among students has largely focused on financial inclusion and financial behavior outcomes. Limited attention has been given to the complex interaction between digital financial technology, psychological stress responses, and postgraduate students' financial experiences in developing countries. Evidence from Nigerian contexts suggests that fintech adoption may simultaneously enhance financial accessibility while also creating psychological pressure associated with debt obligations and financial uncertainty (Adediran & Okonkwo, 2023; Ibrahim & Eze, 2023). Such conditions highlight the importance of integrating technological, economic, and psychological perspectives in order to develop a more comprehensive understanding of financial stress among postgraduate students.

Three primary objectives guide this study. First, the research examines the level of financial stress experienced by Nigerian postgraduate students and identifies major contributing factors. Second, the study analyses the dual role of digital financial technologies by investigating whether these technologies alleviate financial challenges or amplify financial stress among students. Third, the research applies a Cognitive-Behavioral Theory framework to explain how students' perceptions, attitudes, and behavioral responses mediate the relationship between digital financial technology usage and financial stress. Expected contributions include both theoretical and practical implications. Theoretical contributions emerge through integration of fintech adoption literature with cognitive-behavioral perspectives in explaining financial stress within postgraduate education contexts. Practical implications involve recommendations for universities, policymakers, and financial service providers to develop supportive interventions that promote responsible financial technology usage and strengthen financial resilience among students. Comprehensive understanding of the interaction between economic

conditions, digital financial environments, and psychological processes ultimately contributes to improving the financial well-being and academic success of postgraduate students in Nigeria.

2. METHOD

This study employed a conceptual and analytical research design, which is commonly used in position papers aimed at synthesising and critically evaluating existing knowledge rather than generating new empirical data. Conceptual research allows scholars to integrate theoretical perspectives and empirical findings from prior studies in order to construct a coherent analytical argument. Through this approach, the present study develops a reasoned position on whether digital technology functions primarily as a mechanism that reduces financial stress or as a factor that amplifies financial vulnerability among Nigerian postgraduate students. The research adopted a qualitative and theory-driven analytical approach guided by Cognitive-Behavioral Theory (CBT). This theoretical perspective views stress not only as a response to external conditions but also as a result of cognitive appraisal, beliefs, and behavioural responses (Beck, 1976; Dobson & Dozois, 2019). Applying CBT enables the study to interpret financial stress as a multidimensional phenomenon shaped by interactions between economic conditions, technological environments, and students' psychological interpretations of financial challenges.

Data for this study were obtained from secondary sources, primarily peer-reviewed journal articles, policy reports, and empirical studies relevant to financial stress, digital financial technologies, and student financial behaviour. A total of approximately 70 academic sources published between 2015 and 2024 were reviewed and analysed. The selected time frame was intended to capture the rapid development of digital financial technologies and the increasing attention to financial well-being among university students during the past decade. Literature sources were retrieved through systematic searches of several electronic academic databases, including Scopus, Web of Science, Google Scholar, and JSTOR. Searches were conducted using combinations of relevant keywords such as financial stress, postgraduate students, digital financial literacy, financial technology, fintech adoption, Cognitive-Behavioral Theory, and Nigeria. Additional sources were identified through backward and forward citation tracking in order to ensure comprehensive coverage of relevant literature. Selection of literature followed purposive criteria to ensure that included studies directly addressed themes relevant to the research objectives. Table 1 summarises the primary inclusion criteria used in the literature selection process.

Table 1. Literature Selection Criteria

Criterion	Description
Publication type	Peer-reviewed journal articles, policy reports, and scholarly books
Publication year	Studies published between 2015–2024
Research relevance	Studies addressing financial stress, fintech adoption, financial literacy, or psychological aspects of financial behaviour
Population focus	Research involving university or postgraduate students, particularly within developing countries
Accessibility	Full-text publications available through academic databases

A structured literature review matrix was developed as the primary analytical instrument for organising and synthesising the selected studies. The matrix enabled systematic comparison across studies by recording key attributes such as research objectives, methodological approaches, population context, and main findings related to financial stress and technology use. Table 2 presents the main analytical dimensions used in the literature review matrix.

Table 2. Literature Review Matrix Framework

Analytical Dimension	Description
Study context	Country or institutional setting of the study
Research focus	Financial stress, fintech adoption, financial literacy, or psychological well-being
Methodological approach	Quantitative, qualitative, or mixed methods
Technology dimension	Types of digital financial tools examined (e.g., mobile banking, lending apps, budgeting platforms)
Key findings	Main conclusions regarding financial stress and technology use

Data analysis employed a three-stage procedure consisting of thematic analysis, comparative analysis, and theory-driven interpretation. Thematic analysis was conducted to identify recurring patterns and key concepts in the literature related to financial stress, digital financial technology usage, and student financial

behaviour. Comparative analysis was then applied to evaluate contrasting perspectives regarding the role of technology in students' financial lives, particularly between technology as a coping resource supporting financial management (e.g., budgeting applications, mobile banking, and digital financial literacy platforms) and technology as a stress amplifier associated with risks such as digital fraud, impulsive online spending, excessive borrowing, and information overload. Finally, a theory-driven interpretive analysis was conducted using Cognitive-Behavioral Theory (CBT) to explain how students' cognitive interpretations, beliefs, and behavioural responses mediate the relationship between digital financial technology usage and financial stress.

3. RESULT AND DISCUSSION

Result

Distribution of Reviewed Literature

The literature review analysed approximately 70 scholarly sources published between 2015 and 2024 addressing financial stress, digital financial technologies, financial literacy, and psychological aspects of financial behaviour among university students. The reviewed studies were distributed across several thematic areas reflecting the key analytical focus of the study as presented in Table 3.

Table 3. Distribution of Reviewed Literature by Theme (n = 70)

Research Theme	Number of Studies	Example References
Financial stress in higher education	22	(Ogunyemi & Balogun, 2021); (Oluwasegun & Uche, 2022)
Fintech adoption and digital financial behaviour	18	(Adediran & Okonkwo, 2023); (Ibrahim & Eze, 2023)
Financial literacy and financial management tools	15	(Lusardi & Mitchell, 2014); (Ojo & Afolabi, 2024)
Psychological perspectives on stress and coping	15	(Beck, 1976); (Hofmann et al., 2012); (Nwadi et al., 2025)

Table 3 shows that the reviewed literature largely concentrates on financial stress in higher education and fintech adoption among university students. Studies addressing psychological perspectives on financial stress, particularly those applying Cognitive-Behavioral Theory (CBT), constitute a smaller but significant portion of the literature.

Structural Sources of Financial Stress

The reviewed literature identifies several structural factors contributing to financial stress among Nigerian postgraduate students. These factors include rising tuition fees, increasing living costs, limited scholarship opportunities, and unstable income sources. Several studies indicate that financial constraints can disrupt students' academic progress and contribute to delayed graduation (Adebayo & Ibrahim, 2023; Ajayi & Okonkwo, 2023). Additional evidence highlights broader economic pressures affecting students, including unemployment and inflation trends within the Nigerian economy (National Bureau of Statistics, 2023; National Bureau of Statistics, 2024). Studies also report that postgraduate students frequently rely on part-time employment, family support, or informal financial arrangements in order to manage financial demands (Edem et al., 2023; Yusuf & Olayiwola, 2022).

Digital Financial Technology Usage Among Students

The reviewed studies indicate increasing adoption of digital financial technologies among Nigerian university students. These technologies include mobile banking applications, online savings platforms, digital budgeting tools, and fintech-based microcredit services. Table 4 summarises the main categories of digital financial tools identified in the reviewed literature.

Table 4. Categories of Digital Financial Technologies Used by Students

Category of Digital Tool	Example Platforms	Primary Function
Mobile banking platforms	Commercial bank apps	Financial transactions and account management
Digital savings platforms	PiggyVest, Cowrywise	Automated savings and financial planning
Budgeting and expense tracking tools	Mintyn, budgeting apps	Monitoring and controlling personal expenditures
Fintech lending applications	Carbon, FairMoney	Short-term digital credit access

As indicated in Table 4, digital financial tools provide various mechanisms for managing financial resources, including savings automation, expense tracking, and access to digital credit services.

Cognitive-Behavioral Patterns in Financial Stress

The literature also identifies several cognitive and behavioural patterns associated with financial stress among postgraduate students. These patterns reflect how students interpret financial challenges and respond behaviorally to financial pressures, as presented in Table 5.

Table 5. Cognitive-Behavioral Patterns Associated with Financial Stress

Cognitive Pattern	Behavioural Response	Observed Outcome
Catastrophizing financial difficulties	Avoidance of financial planning	Increased anxiety and financial uncertainty
Negative self-evaluation related to financial status	Reduced help-seeking behaviour	Lower financial confidence
Financial pessimism	Impulsive borrowing decisions	Higher financial vulnerability

Table 5 shows that cognitive distortions such as catastrophizing and negative self-evaluation appear frequently in studies examining financial stress among students (Beck, 1976; Dobson & Dozois, 2019). These cognitive patterns are often associated with behavioural responses such as avoidance of financial planning or impulsive borrowing.

Technology-Related Factors Influencing Financial Stress

The reviewed literature identifies both positive and negative outcomes associated with the use of digital financial technologies. Several studies report that digital financial tools support financial planning, savings behaviour, and financial awareness among students (Adeyemo, 2023; Ojo & Afolabi, 2024; Oyediran & Udo, 2023). Other studies highlight potential risks associated with fintech adoption, including impulsive digital borrowing and exposure to online financial fraud (Adediran & Okonkwo, 2023; Ibrahim & Eze, 2023). The reviewed evidence indicates that digital financial technologies interact with students' financial behaviours and cognitive interpretations in shaping financial stress experiences. The findings reveal a combination of structural economic factors, technological environments, and cognitive-behavioural responses within the reviewed literature.

Discussion

The present study examined the relationship between digital financial technology usage and financial stress among Nigerian postgraduate students using Cognitive-Behavioral Theory (CBT) as the analytical framework. Findings from the literature synthesis indicate that financial stress among postgraduate students emerges from the interaction of structural economic conditions, technological financial environments, and cognitive-behavioral processes. Economic pressures such as rising tuition costs, limited financial aid opportunities, and unstable income sources create the structural foundation of financial stress, while students' psychological interpretations and behavioral responses shape how these financial challenges are experienced (Abiogu et al., 2020; Agah et al., 2021). Cognitive-Behavioral Theory emphasizes that emotional and behavioral responses are strongly influenced by individuals' cognitive interpretations of stressful situations (Beck, 1976; Dobson & Dozois, 2019; Okide et al., 2020). Evidence from the reviewed literature indicates that postgraduate students frequently experience maladaptive cognitive patterns when confronting financial difficulties. Catastrophizing financial problems, negative self-evaluation related to financial status, and pessimistic expectations regarding academic completion often intensify financial anxiety (Barrett & Stewart, 2020; Igwe et al., 2022). Such cognitive distortions may also lead to avoidance behaviors, delayed financial planning, and reduced academic engagement, thereby reinforcing the cycle of financial stress.

Findings also reveal the dual role of digital financial technologies in shaping financial experiences among postgraduate students. Digital financial platforms provide various tools that support financial awareness and financial planning. Budgeting applications, mobile banking services, and automated savings platforms enable students to monitor expenditures, organise financial resources, and improve financial decision-making (Adeyemo, 2023; Ojo & Afolabi, 2024; Oyediran & Udo, 2023). Greater financial awareness and structured financial management practices are associated with higher levels of financial confidence and reduced financial uncertainty among students. Evidence from the reviewed studies simultaneously indicates that digital financial technologies may also intensify financial stress when used without adequate financial knowledge or behavioral regulation. Fintech-based lending applications allow rapid access to credit, yet such accessibility may encourage impulsive borrowing and unsustainable debt accumulation (Adediran & Okonkwo, 2023; Ibrahim & Eze, 2023). Digital financial environments may also expose students to financial misinformation, online fraud, and continuous financial decision-making pressures, all of which can increase financial worry and emotional distress (Adeyemo,

2023). These patterns suggest that technological financial tools function as both financial management resources and potential stress amplifiers depending on how students interpret and engage with them. Previous studies examining financial stress among university students have largely focused on structural economic conditions such as tuition costs, inflation, and limited scholarship opportunities (Igbinedion & Adeyemi, 2023; Oladeji & Bamidele, 2022). Current findings extend this literature by demonstrating that financial stress cannot be understood solely through economic factors. Psychological mechanisms and technological environments also influence how students interpret financial challenges and make financial decisions. Integration of Cognitive-Behavioral Theory with fintech adoption literature therefore provides a more comprehensive framework for understanding financial stress within contemporary digital financial environments.

Financial literacy research has consistently emphasized the importance of financial knowledge and budgeting skills in shaping responsible financial behavior (Lusardi & Mitchell, 2014). Findings from this study suggest that financial literacy alone may not sufficiently address financial stress among postgraduate students. Cognitive interpretations of financial situations and emotional responses to financial uncertainty also play critical roles in shaping financial behavior. Financial literacy interventions may therefore become more effective when combined with psychological strategies that address maladaptive cognitive patterns and promote constructive financial decision-making.

Practical implications emerge for universities, policymakers, and financial service providers. Financial stress among postgraduate students requires institutional responses that address both financial and psychological dimensions of student well-being. Financial counseling programs grounded in Cognitive-Behavioral Theory may help students recognize and modify maladaptive financial beliefs while developing healthier financial behaviors. Digital financial literacy initiatives may also strengthen students' capacity to evaluate financial risks, manage digital financial tools responsibly, and make informed financial decisions. Educational institutions may further support student financial resilience by integrating digital financial education into university curricula. Financial literacy modules focusing on budgeting practices, savings automation, debt management, and fraud awareness could strengthen students' ability to navigate increasingly complex digital financial environments. Several limitations should be acknowledged. Conceptual and literature-based methodology limits the ability to directly measure the lived experiences of Nigerian postgraduate students. Evidence synthesized in the study reflects patterns observed in existing literature rather than primary empirical data. Rapid technological changes within the fintech sector may also introduce emerging financial behaviors that remain insufficiently documented in current research. Future research should employ empirical methods such as surveys, experiments, or longitudinal studies to examine the relationship between digital financial technology usage and financial stress among students.

4. CONCLUSION

The study concludes that financial stress among Nigerian postgraduate students emerges from a complex interaction between structural economic constraints, digital financial technology usage, and cognitive-behavioral processes. Digital financial technologies function neither purely as solutions nor solely as sources of stress; rather, their impact depends on how students cognitively interpret and behaviorally engage with these tools. Cognitive-Behavioral Theory highlights that maladaptive thought patterns (catastrophizing financial difficulties or associating financial hardship with personal failure) can intensify financial anxiety and lead to ineffective financial behaviors, even when technological resources for financial management are available. Digital financial platforms therefore hold the potential to reduce financial stress by improving financial awareness, planning, and control, yet the same technologies may also amplify financial vulnerability when accompanied by impulsive borrowing, financial misinformation, or limited financial literacy. A conceptual understanding emerging from this study suggests that effective mitigation of financial stress requires an integrated approach that combines digital financial literacy, responsible fintech engagement, and cognitive-behavioral coping strategies, thereby enabling postgraduate students to transform digital financial technologies into tools for financial resilience rather than sources of financial distress.

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